

# EXAMINATIONS COUNCIL OF LESOTHO

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## EXAMINATIONS ADMINISTRATION HANDBOOK 2024

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## Contents

|                                                                             |    |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| Definitions .....                                                           | 3  |
| Introduction .....                                                          | 6  |
| 1. Preparation for the examination .....                                    | 6  |
| 1.1 Registration of candidates.....                                         | 6  |
| 1.2 Timetable .....                                                         | 6  |
| 1.2.1 Timetable clashes and deviations.....                                 | 6  |
| 1.3 Key Times.....                                                          | 7  |
| 1.3.1 Full Centre Supervision.....                                          | 7  |
| 1.4 Access arrangements .....                                               | 8  |
| 1.4.1 Applications for access arrangements .....                            | 8  |
| 1.5 Additional sittings for large numbers of candidates.....                | 8  |
| 1.6 Dispatch and receipt of question papers and examination materials ..... | 9  |
| 1.7 Security of question papers and examination materials.....              | 11 |
| 1.8 Preparing examination rooms .....                                       | 13 |
| 1.8.1 Examination venue .....                                               | 13 |
| 1.8.2 Examination room.....                                                 | 13 |
| 1.8.3 Display material .....                                                | 13 |
| 1.8.4 Time display.....                                                     | 13 |
| 1.8.5 Display of information .....                                          | 13 |
| 1.9 Seating arrangements.....                                               | 13 |
| 1.10 Invigilation arrangements.....                                         | 14 |
| 1.11 Declaration of interest.....                                           | 16 |
| 2. At the beginning of the examination .....                                | 16 |
| 2.1 Identification of candidates.....                                       | 17 |
| 2.2 Candidate numbers.....                                                  | 17 |
| 2.3 Authorised materials .....                                              | 17 |
| 2.4 Unauthorised materials .....                                            | 17 |
| 2.5 Attendance registers .....                                              | 18 |
| 2.6 Seating plan .....                                                      | 19 |
| 3. Starting the examination.....                                            | 19 |

|                                                                           |    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| 4. During the examination .....                                           | 21 |
| 4.1 Supervision of candidates .....                                       | 21 |
| 4.2 Practical examinations .....                                          | 21 |
| 4.3 Late arrival of candidates .....                                      | 22 |
| 4.3.1 Reasons which ECoL may consider as acceptable for late arrival..... | 22 |
| 4.3.2 Non-acceptable reasons for late arrival .....                       | 22 |
| 4.3.3 Late arrival for a period of Full Centre Supervision .....          | 23 |
| 4.3.4 Candidates arriving after the examination has ended .....           | 24 |
| 4.4 Leaving the examination room .....                                    | 24 |
| 4.5 Irregular conduct during the examination .....                        | 24 |
| 4.6 Emergencies during the examination .....                              | 24 |
| 5. End of the examination.....                                            | 25 |
| 5.1 Finishing the examination .....                                       | 25 |
| 5.2 Collection of answer scripts .....                                    | 25 |
| 5.2.1 <b>NEW</b> Advice note .....                                        | 26 |
| 5.3 Collection of question papers/24-hour security rule .....             | 26 |
| 5.4 Packing and dispatching scripts .....                                 | 26 |
| 6. Malpractice .....                                                      | 27 |
| 6.1 Introduction. ....                                                    | 27 |
| 6.2 Suspected candidate malpractice .....                                 | 27 |
| 6.2.1 Outcomes of candidate malpractice.....                              | 28 |
| 6.3 Suspected centre malpractice .....                                    | 28 |
| 6.3.1 Outcomes of centre malpractice .....                                | 29 |
| 6.4 Communicating outcomes to members of staff and candidates .....       | 29 |
| 7. <b>NEW</b> Results and certificates.....                               | 29 |
| 7.1 Results release .....                                                 | 29 |
| 7.2 Results enquiries .....                                               | 30 |
| 7.2.1 Remark applications .....                                           | 30 |
| 7.2.2 NO RESULT or PENDING enquiries .....                                | 30 |

## **Definitions**

### **Assessment**

The method used to evaluate a candidate's performance e.g. written examination.

### **Centre**

A school, institution, or organisation that has been approved and registered with ECoL for the entry of candidates to ECoL's qualifications and conduct of the assessments for these qualifications.

### **Centre Status**

This is the status awarded to a school, institution or organisation once it has been approved and registered with ECoL. Centre status may be withdrawn by ECoL at any time without giving a reason for doing so.

### **Agreement**

The contract between the Centre and ECoL in the form specified by ECoL from time to time.

### **Centre Supervisor**

A Centre Supervisor is a person legally responsible for an institution approved by ECoL as a centre for its examinations. The duties may be delegated to the Head or Principal of a school, college or similar institution, or the Centre Coordinator, but the responsibilities under this Handbook will remain with the Head of Centre.

### **Centre Coordinator**

The person appointed by the supervisor to act on behalf of the centre, with specific responsibility for the administration of ECoL examinations.

### **Chief Invigilator**

The person appointed by the supervisor to be responsible for the proper conduct of a particular examination in accordance with ECoL's examination regulations.

### **Candidate**

A person who has registered to enter for an assessment.

### **School Candidates**

These are candidates studying at schools which are registered with ECoL as examination centres. School candidates take seven or more subjects according to subject groups as defined by the examination syllabus and qualify for certification upon fulfilling the requirements of the qualification.

### **Private Candidates**

These are usually candidates who are either supplementing one or more subjects, or those writing examinations in parts. Private candidates cannot register for a syllabus with practical and/or school-based assessment component.

## **Access Arrangements**

The Examinations Council of Lesotho's commitment is to provide equal opportunities for candidates in assessments. Arrangements are made to allow candidates with disabilities access to the examinations.

## **Key Times**

These are times specified on the final examination timetable when candidates must be in the examination or under Full Centre Supervision. Key Times are intended to prevent confidential examination information from being shared with candidates before and during their examination.

## **Full Centre Supervision**

Full Centre Supervision is a type of supervision conducted by trained members of staff or invigilators during examinations. When candidates are under Full Centre Supervision, they must either be:

- (i) Under examination conditions or,
- (ii) Supervised by the centre in accordance with the conditions laid out in section 1.3.

## **Session**

A period in a day in which an examination may take place, i.e., am or pm. Each session is usually a duration of not more than three hours.

## **Venue**

An official location where only written examinations or assessments are taken.

## **NEW New or updated information**

Highlights new or updated information to enable centres realise what has changed from the previous examination series.

## Introduction

The regulations and guidelines in this Handbook apply to all ECoL examinations and assessments and are binding to all examination centres. The Handbook guides centres, supervisors, examination officers, and invigilators on how to administer ECoL examinations. The focus is on issues relating to the preparations done for examinations, during examinations, and at the end. Centres should use it to ensure compliance with ECoL regulations.

A breach of the regulations may lead to termination or withdrawal of centre status. A copy of this Handbook must be available in each examination room. Any serious problem with examination materials or procedure should be referred to the Chief Executive Officer of Examinations Council of Lesotho, or the Ministry of Education and Training, or the Police for action.

### 1. Preparation for the examination

This section of the Handbook provides guidelines on processes relating to the preparation for examinations. Examination centres are expected to make all the necessary preparations ahead of the examination series.

#### 1.1 Registration of candidates

Schools must register their candidates for examinations at the beginning of the year. Private candidates are expected to register themselves. Schools may also register some private candidates who have been permitted to sit for examinations at such schools. The registration period for both school and private candidates usually runs from February to May, annually. Guidelines on the registration of candidates can be accessed on ECoL's website.

#### 1.2 Timetable

ECoL prepares and publishes the final timetable well ahead of the examination series. The timetable stipulates the date, session and duration of each sitting. The timetable also provides a range of dates for practical subjects and oral exams. The timetable has been developed in line with Lesotho's Key Times for LGCSE. Every candidate's statement of entry has also been developed using the final timetable. All centres **must** adhere to the timetable published by ECoL.

ECoL always strives to harmonise the question paper details and information on the timetable. However, where some major logistical challenges and clashes are observed, supervisors are urged to advise ECoL about such discrepancies. In case of discrepancy relating to date and duration of papers, the master timetable takes precedence in terms of the date, and the question paper cover takes precedence in terms of the time span of the examination.

##### 1.2.1 Timetable clashes and deviations

A timetable clash refers to the scheduling of two or more subjects at the same time slot/session. In case of timetable clashes that were not identified by ECoL, the centre

must apply for a timetable deviation. The centre must ensure that Key Times are observed and candidates that are not writing remain under Full Centre Supervision. Candidates must be under Full Centre Supervision from the Key Time of the original timetable session until the new start time (see section 1.3). Centres must receive approval from ECoL before administering timetable deviations.

### **1.3 Key Times**

Key Times are a defined point in a timetable session when candidates must be in the examination or under Full Centre Supervision. Key Times are important in preventing confidential examination information from being shared with and amongst candidates before their examination.

The Key Times for LGCSE are 10 a.m. for morning sessions and 2 p.m. for afternoon sessions. If the Key Time is before the start of the examination, candidates must be kept under Full Centre Supervision from the Key Time until the start of the examination. If the Key Time is after the start of the examination, the centre must keep candidates under Full Centre Supervision until the Key Time.

#### **1.3.1 Full Centre Supervision**

Full Centre Supervision means that candidates are supervised by teachers or invigilators in accordance with the conditions laid out below. Centres must ensure that candidates are in a supervised environment and there is at least one supervisor for every 30 candidates.

During Full Centre Supervision, candidates must not:

- be in the same room as any other people except candidates taking the same examination, and their supervisor(s).
- have any access to telephones, mobile phones, laptops/computers, smart wear, or any electronic device with or without internet access.
- have access to any other means of communication outside of the supervised group.
- be allowed to communicate in any way with anyone who is not under Full Centre Supervision at the centre or outside the centre.

During Full Centre Supervision, candidates can:

- have access to their printed books and notes but must not look at books and notes on an electronic device.
- talk to each other.
- leave the room accompanied by a supervisor, and where there is only one supervisor, the centre must ensure the supervisor can get help without leaving the candidates unattended.

Other Full Centre Supervision regulations:

- candidates under Full Centre Supervision who have already taken an examination that others in the group are due to take, for example, an ICT practical exam, must be kept separate from those candidates who have not yet taken the exam.
- if a candidate arrives late for a period of Full Centre Supervision, either before or after an examination, refer to section 4.3.3.
- candidates who do not attend a period of Full Centre Supervision before or after an examination must be reported to ECoL immediately as suspected malpractice.
- centres must keep signed records of all Full Centre Supervision arrangements for candidates. These records must show candidates who were supervised, the start and end times of supervision, and who conducted the supervision. ECoL may ask to see these records at any time until certificates are issued.
- centres must arrange necessary periods of Full Centre Supervision. Failure to make these arrangements will be considered a breach of examination regulations and will be treated as possible centre staff malpractice.

#### **1.4 Access arrangements**

These are arrangements intended to enable candidates with special educational needs to demonstrate their knowledge and skills while adhering to the demands of the assessment. These may be enlarged question papers, extra time, or other arrangements based on a candidate's barrier to assessment.

##### **1.4.1 Applications for access arrangements**

Applications for access arrangements should be submitted at the same time as entries, which is normally from February to May of each year. Arrangements should be based on a candidate's normal way of taking assessment. Thus, centres should not introduce a new way of doing things which is unfamiliar to the candidate's normal way of handling assessment.

Applications from centres must be endorsed by the Special Education unit of the Ministry of Education and Training. Applications for access arrangements must be based on evidence of the candidate's barrier and centres must keep this evidence until the issue of certificates. ECoL may require centres to provide the evidence.

#### **1.5 Additional sittings for large numbers of candidates**

In cases where centres do not have sufficient space or resources for all their candidates to take the examination at the same time, they may arrange one or more additional sittings on the same day scheduled for the exam. This is mainly the case with practical subjects such as ICT.

- (a) Centres must apply in writing for additional sittings at least four weeks before the examination, using Additional Sittings Form.

- (b) Centres must not administer additional sittings without approval from ECoL.
- (c) There must be no contact between groups until all groups have finished the examination. Candidates from the first sitting must be under Full Centre Supervision until the last group starts their examination.
- (d) Key Times and Full Centre Supervision regulations must be followed.
- (e) Detailed plans of additional sittings must be prepared. They should include:
  - timings of additional sittings.
  - seating plans for each sitting.
  - how the centre will apply Full Centre Supervision to prevent groups of candidates from communicating with each other.
  - staff involved in invigilating the examinations and periods of Full Centre Supervision.
  - how the centre will keep confidential material secure between sittings.

ECoL may require these records at any time up to the publication of results and issue of certificates and/or resolution of any malpractice investigation. For practical examinations, centres must supply copies of the seating plan and attendance registers with the supervisor's report.

- (f) Centres must report any known or suspected breach of any agreed supervision arrangements.

## 1.6 Dispatch and receipt of question papers and examination materials

- (a) ECoL will dispatch question papers and other examination material to centres in advance of the examination period.
- (b) **NEW** The question paper bags are packed by component in small, well-labeled boxes. Thus, question papers for each syllabus component are packed in their own box. For example, 0175/01 packed in one box, 0175/02 packed in another box. **The small boxes containing question paper packets must stay sealed until the start of the examination.**
- (c) It is the responsibility of centres to arrange secure collection of question papers from the designated collection venue to the centre or school. Centres must have a procedure in place to ensure the secure transit of question papers from the collection point to the centre and for secure keeping as soon as they arrive at the centre.
- (d) Centres must ensure that all dispatches are checked carefully on receipt. The checking must be done by the centre supervisor and another senior member of staff or Chief Invigilator. The following must be checked:
  - (i) That the correct centre number and address are displayed on the outer packaging of the dispatch.

- (ii) That the correct number of boxes and/or packets were received.
- (iii) That the outer packaging is intact and there is no sign of damage, tampering or opening.
- (e) The confidential materials must be kept secure during the checks until they are transferred to secure storage. **The small boxes containing question paper packets must stay sealed until the start of the examination.**
- (f) Records must be kept by the centre showing that the contents of the dispatch were checked on arrival and that the materials listed in the dispatch note have been received. This can be recorded either by:
- (i) Ticking next to the listed materials directly on the dispatch note, or
  - (ii) By creating a separate list of all materials received in each dispatch at the centre.
- (g) The records must be dated and signed by the supervisor and the member of staff who witnessed the dispatch being checked.
- (h) The signed dispatch notes and other records must be kept by the centre until the end of the examination series and must be available on request if required by ECoL.
- (i) Centres must notify ECoL immediately of any problems, for example, if:
- the question papers have not arrived within two days of the examination.
  - there are any discrepancies between the material received and the dispatch note.
  - the material received is for another centre or does not appear to meet the centre's requirements.
  - there seems to have been a delay in the delivery of the question papers, e.g., materials held up in transit.
  - the material has been damaged.
  - the seal of any question paper packet is broken, or if there is any sign of tampering.
  - a question paper packet has been opened before the examination.

For the last three points above, photos must be taken as evidence and sent to ECoL. The damaged packet must immediately be resealed following the instructions in section 3(l).

(j) If a centre makes entries for a syllabus or component and then withdraws them all, question papers may still be received. If this happens, centres must not open them. They must be stored securely until results are released and certificates issued.

Centres are advised to check boxes of question paper packets against the examination timetable and to arrange them in timetable date and session order. This

will aid in ensuring that the correct box of question paper packets is selected and opened at the time of the examination.

### 1.7. Security of question papers and examination materials

(a) It is the centre's responsibility to ensure the ongoing security of question papers and any other confidential examination material and to take all preventive measures necessary to comply with ECoL regulations.

(b) Question papers **must** be stored unopened, in a place of high security, ideally a strong room or a strong, non-portable safe. If a safe is not available or is of insufficient capacity, a non-portable, lockable, reinforced metal cabinet **must** be used. Where a metal cabinet (such as a filing cabinet) is used as an alternative to a safe, this **must** be fitted with sufficient external locking bars to prevent the doors from being forced open and **must** be bolted to the floor or wall. Padlocks used to secure external locking bars must be strong. The secure container must be locked at all times when examination materials are being stored.

Centres **must** keep the safe in a fixed building where the walls, ceiling and floors are of strong solid construction. The door to the strong room **must** be a solid door, if it is not solid it **must** be reinforced and the door **must** be fitted with strong, tamperproof hinges. Where there are glass panels in the door, these **must** be either reinforced or have metal security bars placed over the panels. The door **must** be fitted with a secure lock. Any internal or external windows **must** be fitted with bars and/or the room **must** be fitted with an alarm system.

The ceiling must be of a concrete construction, such that it does not permit any possible access through the roof, from adjacent rooms, buildings or external areas. Where possible, a windowless secure room would be preferred. The secure room must be locked at all times when examination materials are being stored and the room is unoccupied. The secure room should not be labelled with any sign that shows it is a secure room.

There **must** be a minimum of two authorised people who are key holders and no more than three in total, who have access to the secure strong room. Each key holder should be able to access the examination materials independently, in case other key holders are not available for unexpected reasons. The keys and any access codes to the room must be kept in a secure place where unauthorised people cannot access them. Key holders must have a clear understanding of question paper regulations.

(c) Centres must inform ECoL immediately if the security of question papers, confidential instructions, erratum notices or other assessment material is put at risk by fire, theft, loss, damage, unauthorised disclosure or any other circumstances.

(d) Centres must not open packets of question papers, erratum notices and other examination materials until the time appointed for the examination concerned, except in circumstances where:

(i) ECoL requires centres to open confidential material such as confidential instructions for practical examinations in advance of the examination. Centres must take strict precautions to safeguard the confidential instructions after opening them. They must not remove them from the centre and when not using them, they must keep them in secure conditions. It is the responsibility of the supervisor to ensure that these materials remain confidential and that no information about these materials reaches candidates, either directly or indirectly.

Under no circumstances should centres discuss the confidential instructions with any other centre. Centres should refer any enquiries relating to the confidential instructions to ECoL. Under no circumstances should centres open any question paper packets before the examination is due to start. Centres must refer to their Key times. There are no exceptions.

(ii) Centres must not open erratum notices when they are received unless otherwise stated on the envelope. They must be placed in secure storage until the timetabled date and time that the examination is sat. The candidates should be informed of the contents of the erratum notice before the examination commences.

(iii) Centres must store examination stationery and materials securely at all times so that no unauthorised person has access to them. Any stationery that ECoL provides must be used in ECoL's examinations only.

(e) While downloading and storing confidential materials such as source files for ICT, the following must be observed:

(i) All electronic files must be downloaded and/or transferred in a secure environment by the Head of Centre, or examinations officer, in the presence of another senior member of staff.

(ii) Electronic files must be kept secure at all times and any devices containing the electronic files must be password protected.

(iii) The files must be stored securely until the time they are needed.

(iv) Digital confidential materials must be treated in exactly the same way as printed materials in as far as security is concerned.

(f) If a candidate enters for ECoL examinations at a centre where a relative is employed, the supervisor must ensure that during the examination series, the candidate's relative does not have unaccompanied access to examination materials, either before the examination (e.g., question papers), or after the examination (e.g., answer scripts). If the relative in question is acting as the centre's Chief Invigilator, the centre must make appropriate arrangements to ensure that another person is present for all the examination administration relating to the candidate's examinations. Refer to section 1.11 for further information on declaration of interest.

## **1.8 Preparing examination rooms**

### **1.8.1 Examination venue**

All candidates must sit the examination at a legal centre, which is a school, institution or organisation approved and registered with ECoL. Under no circumstances should examinations be sat at places not approved by ECoL such as hospitals or clinics.

### **1.8.2 Examination room**

All examination rooms must provide candidates with appropriate conditions. Centres must pay attention to such matters as access, heating, ventilation, lighting, cleanliness, safety and the level of extraneous noise. Centres must conduct practical examinations under conditions that will provide all candidates with the opportunity to complete their tasks and to display their true level of attainment in the subject concerned.

### **1.8.3 Display material**

Under no circumstances should any display material that might be helpful to the candidates (e.g., maps, diagrams, wall charts) be visible in the examination room. Centres must take particular care with examinations that are held in laboratories or libraries.

### **1.8.4 Time display**

A reliable clock or some other mechanism for displaying the time must be visible to all candidates in the examination room. Where multiple clocks are needed in large rooms, invigilators should ensure they all show exactly the same time. For candidates using a computer, checks must be made to ensure that the time is correct on each computer.

### **1.8.5 Display of information**

Centres must display the Notice to Candidates poster both inside and outside the examination room for all examinations. Centres must clearly display to all candidates:

- the centre number
- the start and finish times of each examination
- the syllabus title and component code.

## **1.9 Seating arrangements**

The seating arrangements must prevent candidates from overlooking the work of others, intentionally or otherwise. The minimum distance in all directions from the centre of one candidate's chair to the centre of another's, must be 1.25 metres. For multiple-choice papers, centres must increase the space between desks or use extra invigilators. It is important to maximise the distance between candidates' chairs and desks to curb malpractice. Wherever possible, for all written examinations:

- (a) All candidates must face in the same direction.

- (b) All candidates must sit in candidate number order, with candidate numbers labelled on each desk.
- (c) Each candidate must have a separate desk or table of sufficient size to accommodate question papers, maps, equipment and materials for practical examinations and answer booklets/paper.
- (d) If candidates are not working at individual desks, they must be sufficiently far apart that other candidates cannot see their work or make contact with them.
- (e) Where possible centres should not use desks with shelves. If no alternative desks are available, invigilators must check the desks before the beginning of the examination. They must pay special attention to ensuring that nothing is placed on them before the examination.
- (f) Where candidates sit their examinations in a computer laboratory, they must sit in screened booths or at alternate monitors.
- (g) Any candidate who has an illness that cannot allow them to take the examination with others must take the examination in a separate room where the centre can apply all the examination regulations. On completion of the examination, the centre must seal the script in a separate return envelope and provide a note explaining the situation. The centre must pack the script separately from other scripts before dispatching with the main scripts. The centre should inform ECoL in writing.

### 1.10 Invigilation arrangements

- (a) The invigilator is the person in the examination room responsible for the conduct of an examination. He/she is responsible for ensuring that examinations are conducted according to ECoL regulations and has a key role in making sure the integrity of the examination is maintained.
- (b) The supervisor must ensure that suitably qualified and experienced adults carry out invigilation. Whilst the supervisor has the discretion to decide who is suitably qualified and experienced, any relative of a candidate in the examination room is specifically not eligible to serve as the sole invigilator (refer to section 1.11 for further details). The supervisor must ensure that invigilators are fully briefed and trained prior to carrying out the task of invigilation. A record of the training given to invigilators must be kept until certificates are issued. The record should include:
  - (i) Date and time of the training
  - (ii) Who carried out the training
  - (iii) Any materials used for the training.
- (c) Invigilators should **not** be teachers at the centre, whether full-time or part-time. Anyone who has prepared the candidates sitting for assessment is not eligible to be an invigilator. **NEW** Both the teaching and non-teaching staff at the centre should **not** serve as invigilators.

(d) Invigilators must:

- be familiar with the regulations in this Handbook and with the contents of the Notice to Candidates poster. He/she must have a copy of this Handbook in the examination room at all times when there is an exam sitting.
- understand Key Times and Full Centre Supervision regulations.
- keep the examination secure before, during and afterwards.
- understand any specific regulations relating to the subjects being examined.
- give their full attention to the proper conduct of the examination and must not perform any additional task (e.g., marking, using a laptop), in the examination room. Invigilators must be present, mobile and attentive throughout the examination.
- prevent and report suspected malpractice.
- prevent administrative errors.

(e) For written examinations, at least one invigilator must be present for every 30 candidates. The centre must make arrangements such that the invigilator can observe each candidate in the examination room at all times.

(f) For practical examinations:

- (i) There must be one invigilator for every 15 candidates
- (ii) In these examinations it is essential that a teacher of the subject should also be present in the examination room at the start of the examination and as necessary thereafter, to deal with technical difficulties that may arise, including matters of safety.
- (iii) Invigilators must make sure candidates do not communicate with each other, especially where they need to move from one part of the room to another.
- (iv) Large numbers of candidates:
  - candidates may be divided into two groups or more (refer to section 1.5).
  - candidates may be taking the examination or they may be under Full Centre Supervision before or after the examination.
  - all groups must take the examination on the same day, with minimum possible delay between sessions. Centres should consider the time needed to set up the system and allow time in case anything unexpected happens.
  - the groups must be kept apart until all candidates have finished the examination.
  - the examination must be kept secure at all times. Candidates waiting to take the examination must not find out anything about the contents of the examination.

- (g) For both written and practical examinations, when only one invigilator is present, he/she must be able to summon assistance easily, without leaving the examination room and without disturbing the candidates. A change of invigilators during an examination is allowed, provided that the number of invigilators present in the room does not fall below the number prescribed. A record must be kept of any change in invigilation during the examination.

Centres must keep signed records of the invigilation arrangements for each examination session. Centres must also keep signed records of the supervision arrangements for candidates under Full Centre Supervision, in order to comply with the regulations regarding the Key Times. ECoL may require these records at any time up to the publication of results and issue of certificates and/or resolution of any maladministration or malpractice investigation.

### **1.11 Declaration of interest**

(a) If a staff member at a centre including the Head of Centre has an interest in a person taking assessment or taking ECoL assessment themselves, they must complete the Declaration of Interest Form. They must hand the form to the supervisor who will send a copy of the form to ECoL. Centres must store the original form for one year and it must be available for inspection by ECoL at any time.

(b) Examples of relationships include, but are not limited to:

- a close relative (including children, grandchildren, spouse or partner).
- a relative you have regular contact with.
- a close friend.
- a colleague.
- any person whose relationship to you could compromise the integrity of the centre or ECoL's assessments.
- any person whose relationship to you could compromise your integrity or good name, as a centre employee or otherwise, if you did not disclose the relationship.

Please note that you should complete the Declaration of Interest Form as soon as you know that the person concerned will be, or has been, entered for ECoL examinations.

## **2. At the beginning of the examination**

Centres must ensure that candidates take the examination session indicated on the final timetable. Centres are expected to start the examination at the time indicated on the timetable. In case of emergency, they are permitted to start the examination at any time within the session but must ensure that the Key Time and Full Centre Supervision regulations are observed. Any deviations must be reported to ECoL. For ICT practical tests, before the start of the examination, centres must ensure that the date and time settings on all computers are correct.

All candidates entered for examinations in a session must be under Full Centre Supervision at the Key Time. Centres are responsible for informing candidates of examination times and any changes to the timetable. ECoL reserves the right to visit centres during the period of examinations to inspect the arrangements made for the security of confidential examination material and for the conduct of examinations.

### **2.1 Identification of candidates**

Invigilators must be satisfied with the identity of every candidate attending each examination session. The supervisor must ensure that arrangements are in place to enable invigilators to carry out thorough checks on the identity of all candidates. The centre must require private candidates who are not known to the centre to present documentary evidence (e.g., National ID, a valid passport or a driver's license), and check each time they attend an examination session that they are the same person who has entered for the examination. Only those people authorised by the supervisor are allowed in the examination room. Identity checks must not disturb any candidates who are already taking their examination.

### **2.2 Candidate numbers**

The centre must inform all candidates of their candidate numbers in advance of the examination. The candidate number should always be displayed on each candidate's table.

### **2.3 Authorised materials**

Candidates may take into the examination room only those articles, instruments or materials that are expressly permitted in the rubric of a question paper, stationery list or in the syllabus booklet for the subject being examined. Candidates must provide their own pens, pencils, ink, drawing instruments and erasers. Candidates must write their answers legibly in black or dark blue ink. Invigilators should warn candidates that the use of pale blue or black ink contributes to illegibility. Candidates must not use red ink. They must use a soft pencil (type B or HB is recommended) for multiple-choice papers.

Candidates may use calculators in examinations unless the relevant syllabus or the front of the question paper states that calculators are prohibited. If the syllabus or the front of the question paper does not state that calculators are prohibited or does not mention calculators, candidates can use a calculator if they want to. Candidates must clear any information and/or programs stored in the calculator's memory before and after the examination. Invigilators should check a sample of the candidates' calculators before the start of the examination to make sure they meet the regulations stipulated above. Where a map is used as part of the question paper, the use of a string and/or magnifying glass is permitted but not essential.

### **2.4 Unauthorised materials**

Possession of unauthorised material by a candidate during the examination is a serious breach of examination regulations and may result in forfeiture of examination

grades. Centres must report all instances to ECoL. Unauthorised materials include revision notes of any kind, calculator cases, instruction leaflets or any instructions or formulae printed on the lid or cover of a calculator or mathematical set, bags, non-transparent pencil cases, any packaging with images or text on it, computers of any sort, electronic or radio communication or recording devices, mobile telephones, 'smart wear' such as smart glasses and smart watches, cameras, Bluetooth headsets or portable music players (this is a non-exhaustive list).

Electronic items, including mobile phones and Bluetooth devices, must be switched off and must be left outside the examination room. Other types of unauthorised material must either be left outside the examination room or handed to the invigilator before the examination commences. Unauthorised materials handed to the invigilator must be placed out of reach of the candidates before the examination commences. Invigilators should check a sample of the candidates' calculators before the start of the examination to make sure they meet the regulations stipulated above. Candidates are not allowed to take their own copies of mathematical tables into the examination room.

The examples given above do not include every possible item that would be considered 'unauthorised'. Supervisors and invigilators should use their judgement for any items not on the list by asking themselves whether the item potentially enables a candidate to conceal or access information in the examination room.

## **2.5 Attendance registers**

Before the examination, ECoL will send attendance registers to centres. Centres must complete these documents for recording the presence of candidates, in accordance with the instructions printed on them. Attendance registers are printed in date and session order for all timetabled components. Centres must check that they have received attendance registers for each component being taken at the centre and must report any deficiencies immediately. Candidates' names are printed on the attendance registers exactly as they will appear on the statements of results and certificates. Centres must report any errors in candidates' details at once using a Candidate Entry Amendment Form.

If a candidate's details do not appear on the attendance register, the centre must enter them by hand at the end of the list on the attendance register. If a candidate is present for the examination, he/she must be marked as present on the attendance register with a tick (✓) on the space provided. All candidates present must sign the attendance register next to their names.

Absent candidates should be marked with an alphabet **A** in the space provided next to the name of the absent candidate. Invigilators must check and sign the attendance register at the end of the examination. The centre must keep a copy of all completed attendance registers. ECoL may ask to see these at any time until certificates are issued.

## 2.6 Seating plan

Centres must produce a seating plan before each examination and keep the signed records of the seating arrangements for each session. This should be in duplicate, one copy must be dispatched with scripts to ECoL and another copy should be kept by the centre as a record. A seating plan must also show the position of the invigilator's desk and the direction the candidates are facing.

For each examination session, invigilators must check that the seating plan is accurate and update it if necessary. **NEW** Candidate numbers of absent candidates should be included on the seating plan, marked with the alphabet **A** on top of the written candidate number, to indicate where the absent candidate was supposed to be seated. ECoL may require the seating plan from centres at any time up to the issue of certificates.

## 3. Starting the examination

An examination is deemed to be in progress from the time the candidates enter the examination room until all the scripts have been collected. Before candidates are permitted to start work, the invigilator must carry out the following:

- (a) Ensure that the candidates are seated in accordance with the prescribed seating arrangements.
- (b) Inform the candidates that they are now subject to the regulations of the examination and they should follow the rules detailed on the 'Notice to Candidates' poster they can see inside and outside the room. If candidates have a question at any time, they must raise their hand and wait until an invigilator comes to them.
- (c) Warn the candidates that they must hand in any unauthorised material not previously handed in (refer to section 2.4). This should include any food or drinks, which may only be allowed in the examination room with the specific approval of the centre supervisor. Centres must warn candidates about the severe penalties if they are found in possession of unauthorised material.
- (d) Question paper packets must be collected from the secure storage as close to the start of the examination as possible. Once these have been removed from secure storage, they must not be left unattended at any time.
- (e) Check that the candidates have all the necessary materials to enable them to complete the examination.
- (f) A check should be made by two staff members to ensure that the packets are the correct ones for the examination and that they are intact (including all seals). They must also check that the details on the label are correct. This includes checking that the centre number, examination date, session, syllabus and component number are correct. When these checks have been completed, the question paper packets can be opened and handed out to candidates, but they must not open them until instructed.

Question paper packets must normally remain sealed so that the invigilator can open them in the presence of the candidates. There are special circumstances when such a procedure is not possible. For example, where more than one room is used or when there are large numbers of candidates, it would be more sensible to open the packet in one room.

The question paper packets should be shown to at least one candidate before opening, to verify that they are the correct ones for the session. It is the responsibility of the invigilator to report to the supervisor any grounds for suspicion about the security of the examination papers. The supervisor and the Chief Invigilator of the centre must notify ECoL immediately, and subsequently submit a full written report.

- (g) Draw candidates' attention to the instructions and information printed on the front of the question paper and ask them to check that the invigilator has given them the examination paper for the correct syllabus and component. Invigilators should inform candidates of any additional materials, in addition to the question paper, that they should have in the examination, such as the map in geography.
- (h) Inform candidates of the contents of any erratum notices. The invigilator must not give any information to candidates about suspected errors in the question paper except those stated on any erratum notices received.
- (i) Inform candidates that:
  - they must write their answers legibly in black or dark blue ink or ball-point pen.
  - they must not use any form of correcting medium including correcting fluid, correcting pens and correcting tape. They should neatly cross through rough work but not obliterate it.
  - they must not use highlighters and glue unless the question paper gives instructions to the contrary.
  - they must do all work (including any rough work) on the examination stationery, unless the question paper gives instructions to the contrary. The centre must include it with the answers sent to ECoL.
  - in the case of multiple-choice papers, they must do any rough work on the question paper.
  - they must write their name, centre number, candidate number and the component code/paper details on their answer paper, where applicable, and complete any other details as required.
- (j) Remind the candidates that they are forbidden to communicate in any way with, seek assistance from, or give assistance to, any person whilst they are in the examination room.

- (k) Inform the candidates of the time allowed for the examination and announce clearly that they can open the question paper and may begin to read the questions and write their answers. Under no circumstances must invigilators permit candidates extra time, before the official start of the examination, to read through the question paper. Invigilators should also remind candidates of the start and finish times of the examination.
- (l) If the invigilator opens the wrong question paper packet by mistake, the question papers must not be given to the candidates.

The supervisor should report to ECoL immediately and the following steps should be followed:

- the question paper packet should not be resealed. Photographs of the opened packet should be taken, but caution should be taken not to reveal contents of the question paper.
- the invigilator should put the opened packet in a large envelope and write on it 'question papers', the syllabus and component code, the date and time of the correct examination.
- the envelope should be sealed and signed over the seal by the invigilator and the supervisor to show that both have witnessed the packet being resealed. Then a photograph of the signatures and the new seal should be taken.
- the sealed envelope should be returned to secure storage.
- the correct examination should be conducted once the process has been completed.
- the supervisor must send a full report stating why and how the packet was opened in error, who opened it and when, who has had access to the packet since it has been opened, and who has had access to the question paper since it has been opened.

Candidates may need Full Centre Supervision while the process described above is being done.

## **4. During the examination**

### **4.1 Supervision of candidates**

Invigilators must supervise the candidates throughout the whole examination and always give complete attention to this duty. They must not read through any question papers.

### **4.2 Practical examinations**

During a practical examination, movement by candidates and spoken instructions may be necessary. Invigilators must limit these to what is essential to achieve the objectives

of the examination without compromising the security of the examination. More guidance can be obtained from the relevant Subject Officers at ECoL.

### **4.3 Late arrival of candidates**

(a) Centres may allow a candidate who arrives after the starting time for an examination to enter the examination room to sit the examination. However, centres must warn the candidate that ECoL reserves the right not to accept the script.

(b) When deciding whether to accept any of the work completed by a candidate who arrived late, ECoL will pay particular attention to the extent to which it considers the security of the examination was maintained, especially concerning the Key Time.

(c) The centre, at its discretion, may allow the full time for the examination for a candidate who arrives after the scheduled starting time. In such cases, the centre should report this to ECoL.

(d) In each case where a candidate is admitted late into an examination room the following rules apply:

- (i) The centre must send the answer script to ECoL in the normal way.
- (ii) The supervisor must send a full report, which must include the following information:
  - the reason for the late arrival of the candidate, including details of any arrangements made for the candidate to reach the centre.
  - the centre's actual start and finish times of the examination.
  - the time at which the candidate started the examination.
  - the time at which the candidate finished the examination.
  - the Key Time of the examination.
  - a statement regarding any possible breach of examination security arising from the candidate's late arrival, including information about the extent to which the candidate was under supervision from the actual starting time of the examination.

#### **4.3.1 Reasons which ECoL may consider as acceptable for late arrival**

In cases where the candidate is late for good reason and ECoL is satisfied that there has been no breach of examination security (e.g., supervision can be guaranteed by the centre in respect of the Key Time), ECoL will accept the work completed in the whole examination, including any work completed during any additional time allowed to compensate for the late arrival. Examples of acceptable reasons are sudden illness or transport difficulties beyond the candidate's control.

#### **4.3.2 Non-acceptable reasons for late arrival**

In a case where a candidate is late because of negligence or oversight, and ECoL is satisfied that there has been no breach of security (e.g., supervision can be

guaranteed by the centre in respect of the Key Time), ECoL will accept the work completed in normal examination time. However, ECoL will not accept any work completed in any additional time allowed. Examples of reasons which are not acceptable are oversleeping or misreading of the timetable.

#### **4.3.3 Late arrival for a period of Full Centre Supervision**

- (a) Centres may allow a candidate who arrives after the starting time for a period of required Full Centre Supervision prior to an examination to enter the supervised conditions and then take the examination. However, centres must warn the candidate that ECoL reserves the right not to accept the script.
- (b) When deciding whether to accept any of the work completed by a candidate who arrived late for a period of required Full Centre Supervision for an examination, ECoL will pay particular attention to the extent to which it considers the security of the examination was maintained, especially in respect of the Key Time.
- (c) If a candidate arrives late for a period of required Full Centre Supervision before an examination, but after the Key Time for the examination, the candidate can only be permitted to enter Full Centre Supervision if they do not have any contact or communication with any other candidates currently under Full Centre Supervision.
- (d) In each case where a candidate is admitted late into a period of Full Centre Supervision, the following rules apply:
  - (i) The centre must send the answer script to ECoL in the normal way.
  - (ii) The supervisor must send a full report, which must include the following information:
    - the reason for the late arrival of the candidate, including details of any arrangements made for the candidate to reach the centre.
    - the centre's actual start and finish times for the period of Full Centre Supervision and the examination, including details of any arrangements for dealing with large numbers of candidates in practical examinations.
    - the time at which the candidate entered Full Centre Supervision.
    - the Key Time of the examination.
    - a statement regarding any possible breach of examination security arising from the candidate's late arrival, including information about the extent to which the candidate was under supervision from the actual starting time of the period of Full Centre Supervision, until they entered supervised conditions at the centre.

#### 4.3.4 Candidates arriving after the examination has ended

- (a) If the examination has already ended and other candidates who have sat the examination are under Full Centre Supervision, the late candidate must not be allowed to communicate with them in any way.
- (b) A candidate who arrives after the other candidates have been released from the examination room must be dealt with as absent and centres should **not** allow them to take the examination. In such cases, the centre must advise the candidate that ECoL may issue a 'No Result' in the subject affected.
- (c) If a candidate arrives late for an afternoon paper that a centre has, with the approval of ECoL, rescheduled to a morning session, the centre may permit the candidate to take the paper at the published time, provided that the candidate has not had any contact with candidates who sat the paper at the rescheduled time. In such cases, acceptance of the answer script will be at the discretion of ECoL.

#### 4.4 Leaving the examination room

- (a) Candidates who leave the examination room temporarily must be accompanied by a member of staff. Candidates should not be given extra time to complete their examination. In cases where special consideration is applied for (e.g., illness), the centre may allow such candidates extra time to compensate for their temporary absence.
- (b) Whether or not they leave the examination room early, candidates may not remove any question papers or transcribed content of question papers. This includes such methods as writing questions on statements of entry, inserting question content into calculators etc., (this is not an exhaustive list). **Centres must apply the 24-hour rule for the security of question papers and their contents.**

#### 4.5 Irregular conduct during the examination

- (a) Whenever possible, the invigilator must remove and retain any unauthorised material discovered in the possession of a candidate in the examination.
- (b) The supervisor must ensure that they report all cases of irregularity or misconduct in connection with the examination to ECoL as soon as possible. The supervisor is empowered to expel a candidate from the examination room, but they should only take such action when it is felt to be essential or when the continued presence of a candidate would cause disruption to other candidates.
- (c) Any infringement of the regulations may lead to a disqualification of the candidate. The decision on disqualification rests with ECoL.

#### 4.6 Emergencies during the examination

The invigilator must take the following action in the event of an emergency:

- if necessary, evacuate the examination room.



- ensure that the candidates are fully supervised to ensure they cannot communicate with anyone or access examination information.
- ensure that all the question papers and answer scripts are left in the examination room and that the room is secured.
- note the time and length of the interruption.
- allow the candidates the full working time prescribed for the examination.
- if there is only a small number of candidates, consider the possibility of taking the candidates, with question papers and scripts to another place to complete the examination.
- make a full report of the incident and the action taken, for immediate submission to ECoL.

## **5. End of the examination**

### **5.1 Finishing the examination**

Five minutes before the end of the examination, the invigilator must inform the candidates of the time remaining. At the end of the examination, the invigilator must tell the candidates to stop writing and to place their pens/pencils on their desks immediately. Where invigilators permit candidates who arrived late the full working time to complete their examination (see section 4.3), they can allow such candidates to continue after the normal finishing time and tell them to stop writing after the additional time allowed. The invigilator must instruct the candidates to:

- Ensure that they have entered all the required information on their answer scripts.
- Ensure that their answers are correctly numbered.
- Check they have neatly crossed through any rough work.
- Assemble any loose sheets, including rough work and inserts where necessary, in the order in which they attempted the questions and fasten these and any supplementary answer sheets to the back of their answer scripts, or as otherwise instructed, with the string or tags provided by the centre (they must not use paperclips or staples).

### **5.2 Collection of answer scripts**

- The invigilator should inform candidates that they are still under examination conditions and must remain silent and stay seated until they are released from the room.
- Centres must ensure that they collect all answer scripts before the candidates are allowed to leave the examination room. In doing so, invigilators should pay particular attention to instructions regarding the return or otherwise of question paper inserts.

- (c) Invigilators must sort answer scripts by attendance register order and check to make sure there is a script for every candidate marked as present and that candidates have used their correct centre and candidate numbers.
- (d) Answer scripts are confidential between the candidate and ECoL. They may not be read or photocopied by any person prior to dispatch, unless this is specifically required by ECoL. If a candidate or other unauthorised person removes a script from the examination room, the centre must advise ECoL of the circumstances of the irregularity in writing. The candidate should be warned that ECoL may not accept the script.

#### **5.2.1 NEW Advice note**

The advice note is a record of all scripts that have been packaged for dispatch to ECoL. Once scripts have been checked against the attendance register, the advice note should then be completed using scripts, as a record of all scripts which have been enclosed in the scripts bag or envelope.

### **5.3 Collection of question papers/24-hour security rule**

- (a) Only the designated centre staff responsible for the collection of question papers may take a copy of the question paper from the examination room.
- (b) The centre must collect all question papers and any other examination material at the end of the examination. Question papers must be retained under secure conditions until at least 24 hours have passed after the end of the examination or Key Time, whichever is later. Centres must fully audit the number of question papers at the end of the examination and verify that this matches the number issued, before candidates are released from supervision.
- (c) After 24 hours have passed from the Key Time for the relevant session, centres may return question papers to candidates or centre staff at their discretion.
- (d) Centres must keep all empty question paper packets securely until certificates are issued. ECoL may require them for investigations for suspected malpractice cases.

### **5.4 Packing and dispatching scripts**

Candidates' answer scripts should be kept in a secure place before sending them to ECoL. Centres should dispatch all answer scripts without delay after an examination, on the same day whenever possible and by the most expedient method. If the centre has to store answer scripts before dispatch, they must be sealed and kept under the same secure conditions as question paper packets and other confidential examination material.

The following steps should be followed when packing scripts.

- (a) The scripts and corresponding attendance register, seating plan, and advice note must be placed in a script packet. Centres must keep copies of all

completed attendance registers and other examination documents securely. ECoL may ask to see these at any time until certificates are issued.

- (b) If one script packet is not large enough, two or more packets can be used. The register and other documents should be placed in the first packet. Where there are more than one script packets, invigilators should label them clearly, 1 of 2, 2 of 2, etc.
- (c) If all the candidates for a component are absent, the attendance register and seating plan should still be completed and enclosed in the script packet and returned to ECoL.
- (d) Invigilators must shade 'Absent' on multiple-choice answer sheets for absent candidates. These must be enclosed together with other answer sheets.
- (e) Invigilators should ensure that the packaging is secure so that the contents do not get lost or damaged.

## **6. Malpractice**

### **6.1 Introduction.**

Malpractice and maladministration are those actions that break examination regulations and potentially threaten the integrity of examinations and certificates. Malpractice can happen before, during or after timetabled examinations and other assessments.

Malpractice can be:

- intentional, aiming to give an unfair advantage in an examination or assessment.
- caused by people being careless, forgetful or unaware of examination regulations.
- a result of circumstances beyond anyone's control.

It is the responsibility of the Head of Centre to make sure candidates and centre staff know their responsibilities as set out in ECoL regulations. The Head of Centre must immediately report to ECoL, all cases of potential and suspected malpractice and maladministration.

### **6.2 Suspected candidate malpractice**

The following are examples of malpractice by candidates. The list is not exhaustive and ECoL may consider other instances of malpractice at its discretion.

- disruptive behavior in the examination room (including talking or attempting to talk to other candidates and/or using offensive language).
- seeking, obtaining, receiving, exchanging or passing on confidential or fake examination material in any way.
- failing to follow an invigilator's instructions.

- failing to follow the conditions of supervision designed to maintain the security of examinations.
- bringing unauthorised materials into the examination room or accessing unauthorised materials during the examination (refer to section 2.4).
- pretending to be someone else, or arranging for another person to take one's place in an examination.
- the inclusion of inappropriate, offensive or obscene material in scripts or coursework.
- copying from another candidate.
- collusion.
- deliberately destroying another person's work.
- not giving sources and/or submitting another person's work as if it is their own.
- altering, falsifying or misrepresenting any result's information, including certificates.
- behaving in such a way as to undermine the integrity of the examination.

#### **6.2.1 Outcomes of candidate malpractice**

Outcomes of candidate malpractice may include:

- giving a warning to candidate(s).
- deduction of marks or award of no marks for a component.
- issue a 'No Result' for the syllabus.
- disqualify candidate from the subject or all subjects taken in the series.
- ban a candidate from entering ECoL examinations for a specified period.

ECoL can apply outcomes not listed above.

#### **6.3 Suspected centre malpractice**

The following are examples of malpractice by centre staff. The list is not exhaustive and ECoL may consider other instances of malpractice at its discretion.

- failure to keep examination materials secure and confidential.
- moving the session or date of a timetabled examination without notifying ECoL and obtaining permission.
- failure to maintain Full Centre Supervision in respect of the Key Time.
- failure to maintain proper invigilation.
- not keeping candidates' work confidential.
- not keeping candidate computer files secure.
- alterations of answers on the candidates' work.

- assisting or prompting candidates with answers.
- obtaining unauthorised access to examination material prior to an examination.
- assisting candidates in the production of coursework, beyond that permitted by the regulations.
- breach of the 24-hour security rule, that is, any attempt to remove or reveal the content of the examination outside the examination room, before 24 hours have passed.
- behaving in a way that undermines the integrity of the examination.

### **6.3.1 Outcomes of centre malpractice**

All Centres that are found guilty will be penalised after being accorded a hearing. Examples of outcomes include:

- giving a warning to centre staff.
- ban members of staff from any involvement in administering ECoL examinations for a specified period.
- ban members of staff from participation in examination activities such as marking for a specified period.
- not allowing the centre to make entries for specific examinations and/or syllabuses.
- suspension of invigilators.
- suspension and/or termination of centre status.

ECoL can apply outcomes not listed above.

### **6.4 Communicating outcomes to members of staff and candidates**

The Head of Centre must tell the people concerned about the outcome(s). Centres should keep records of malpractice outcomes for future reference. Where appropriate, these should be shared with new members of staff, such as a new Head of Centre or examination officer.

## **7. NEW Results and certificates**

### **7.1 Results release**

Once results are released, centres and candidates are provided with provisional results in the form of statements of results. Centres should give candidates their printed statements as soon as they are provided by ECoL. It is the responsibility of centres to give candidates their results. Private candidates should collect their results from the respective centres where they sat examinations. ECoL reserves the right to amend published provisional results. The final results are confirmed by the issue of certificates.

## 7.2 Results enquiries

Centres and candidates can submit enquiries about their results a month after publication or release of results.

### 7.2.1 Remark applications

ECoL carries out extensive quality checks and validation processes before results are released. However, candidates who wish to have their results checked can apply for remark. The outcome of remarked results is published after two to three weeks from the deadline of applications for remark. Candidates whose grades change after remark will be refunded half of the remark fee they paid. To claim the refund, they should submit the old statement of results and proof of payment. It is the responsibility of candidates to follow up on results enquiries. Applications are made on the Ecol website.

### 7.2.2 NO RESULT or PENDING enquiries

A 'NO RESULT' is normally issued if a candidate has not completed some of the components of assessment for a particular syllabus. 'PENDING' indicates that a result cannot be issued at the time of results release, either due to a pending outcome of malpractice or for other reasons. There is usually no fee charged for this category of enquiries, except where a candidate sat for a different syllabus option from the one they had registered for. In this case a candidate would be liable for payment of amendment fee. It is the responsibility of centres and candidates to follow up on results enquiries. ECoL cannot accept requests submitted after the deadline for results enquiries.

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